

How Much Do Statutes Disagree?

Measuring Definitional Fragmentation Across a Legal System

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Abstract

Drafting manuals agree that a term should carry a stable meaning across a legal system. Whether real systems comply has never been measured, because settling it requires every statutory definition in a jurisdiction, extracted from the instrument that made it. This article supplies that measurement for Saudi Arabia — 290 instruments, 1,920 defined terms, 3,318 definitions — and argues that the measurement is worth less than the two distinctions needed to perform it. The first separates *indexical* definitions, where an instrument defines ‘the Law’ as itself, from substantive ones; indexical definitions are the most repeated and cannot disagree. The second separates lexical from substantive divergence: 61.5 per cent of shared substantive terms are worded differently, and most of that is paraphrase. Reading the 12 most widely shared terms yields 4 genuine conflicts. Fragmentation is real but narrow, and therefore a tractable target for drafting reform.

Keywords

statutory definitions; legislative drafting; interpretation; Saudi Arabia; legal corpora; terminological consistency

Word count

8,026 words, including footnotes.

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Conflict of interest

The author declares no conflict of interest.

Ethics approval

Not applicable. The study involves no human participants, no animal subjects and no personal data. It analyses published national legislation only.

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Data availability

The corpus, its glossary layer, and the analysis and figure scripts that reproduce every number and figure reported in the article are openly available at <https://github.com/Abdullah-m7/saudi-legal-corpus-ai> and archived on Zenodo under the MIT licence (10.5281/zenodo.22019183; concept DOI 10.5281/zenodo.22019182).

Related work by the author

Two companion manuscripts drawing on the same corpus are under review elsewhere: one describing the corpus as a resource, and one analysing its citation network. Neither overlaps with the present article's contribution, and neither is under consideration by this journal.

Legal status of the sources

The article analyses a non-official research corpus. Nothing in it constitutes legal advice, and the binding text of any instrument is the Arabic original published in *Umm al-Qura*. Instrument identifiers are given as recorded in the corpus registry.